

The Map for Tonight

Act One only · everyone seated · scripts and pencils · Six Characters · Village Players · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi

THE TWO MOVES, EACH PART

1 · The Italian way. Fast, flat, no emotion, no stopping — it drills the cues and lets us hear the shape.

2 · The action. For each line I call, say “**I ____ you**” — subject, verb, object. One verb per thought. Feeling comes out of doing.

ORDER OF THE EVENING

Warm up → then the six parts in order, each read the Italian way then actioned → a short break after The Veil → finish with a bit of practice.

The notions we are working with

Read to discover, not to perform

Nothing tonight is a performance — the acting comes in August. We read to *find out what is there*. Try things, guess, be wrong out loud.

The Italian way (*l'italiana*)

Say the lines as fast as humanly possible — flat, no emotion, no pauses, cues snapped up the instant they land. No acting allowed. It drills the cues (the hardest thing to learn is the *other* person's last words) and lets us feel the true shape and speed of a scene.

The action — subject · verb · object

For each line I call, name what you are doing to the other person as “**I ____ you.**” It must fit that frame, so it is always something you *do* to someone — *I warn you, I coax you, I shame you* — never a mood (*not* “I am sad”) and never an adverb. Feeling comes out of doing.

One action per thought — not per line

A long speech turns three or four times. Mark where the verb changes: the Father goes *I explain* → *I plead* → *I attack* inside one speech. The turns are the map of the scene.

Learn the cue with the line

The Italian way trains this: you come in on the other person's last words, so learn them together. Half of “knowing the play” is knowing exactly when you speak.

Let the laugh curdle

Act One is funny — and then suddenly not. Notice where the room laughs and where the laugh must die (the veil; “He calls it pity”). Never kill the comedy; let it *turn*.

Play each one true

The Father is panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture. The Step-Daughter lays down evidence, cold, never screams. The Mother is scored around the object and the silence, not the tears. The Son shuts doors. The Manager is a director first.

Warm-up • 18:00

Ten to fifteen minutes, seated: voice and breath. Loosen the tongue for the fast reading to come. Then we begin, part by part.

Part by part

18:15 Part I — The Rehearsal

In it: The Manager, Player 1, Player 2, Player 3 · The Manager cracks the whip; the Players drag their feet.

- 1 **Read it the Italian way.** The whole part, script in hand, as fast as you can — flat, no emotion, no pauses, cues snapped up the instant they land.
- 2 **Action it — line by line.** For each line I point to, say what you are doing to the other person as *subject – verb – object*: “**I ____ you.**” One strong verb per thought, pencilled in.

Worked example **Player 1:** “We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.” → **I save face.**

Ask (one sentence, in character):

- **The Manager** What kind of day are you having before they walk in? / What do you really think of the play you're forced to rehearse? / What would make tonight a good night for you?
 - **Player 1** What do you think you're owed in this company? / What was the best role you ever played — and how long ago? / What are you afraid the others see when they look at you?
 - **Player 2** What keeps you patient with all of them? / What do you do here that nobody thanks you for? / What would you rather be doing?
 - **Player 3** What are you still excited about? / What do you want to learn from the older two? / What don't you understand about this job yet?
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18:30 Part II — The Arrival

In it: The Father, The Step-Daughter, The Manager, the Players · The Father talks his way in; the Step-Daughter throws “Valentine” like a stone.

- 1 **Read it the Italian way.** The whole part, script in hand, as fast as you can — flat, no emotion, no pauses, cues snapped up the instant they land.
- 2 **Action it — line by line.** For each line I point to, say what you are doing to the other person as *subject – verb – object*: “**I ____ you.**” One strong verb per thought, pencilled in.

Worked example **The Step-Daughter:** “We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.” → **I dare you.**

Ask (one sentence, in character):

- **The Father** What do you need them to believe? / Which story do you most want told — and why now?
 - **The Manager** When do you stop wanting to throw them out? / What first makes you curious instead of angry?
 - **The Step-Daughter** Why sing “Valentine” to a room of strangers?
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18:52 Part III — The Veil

In it: *The Mother, The Father, The Step-Daughter* · *He lifts the veil against her will; she names what he did.*

- 1 **Read it the Italian way.** The whole part, script in hand, as fast as you can — flat, no emotion, no pauses, cues snapped up the instant they land.
- 2 **Action it — line by line.** For each line I point to, say what you are doing to the other person as *subject – verb – object*: “I ____ you.” One strong verb per thought, pencilled in.

Worked example **The Mother:** “But you drove me away.” → **I correct you.**

Ask (one sentence, in character):

- **The Mother** What are you trying to stop from happening? / Who are you most afraid for? / Why can't you speak the way the others do?
- **The Step-Daughter** What do you want them to see that the Father won't say? / What has he done to you?

19:25 Part IV — The Defence

In it: *The Father, The Mother, The Step-Daughter, The Manager* · *The big one — the Father's defence must be a fight, not a lecture.*

- 1 **Read it the Italian way.** The whole part, script in hand, as fast as you can — flat, no emotion, no pauses, cues snapped up the instant they land.
- 2 **Action it — line by line.** For each line I point to, say what you are doing to the other person as *subject – verb – object*: “I ____ you.” One strong verb per thought, pencilled in.

Worked example **The Father:** “Words are the whole trouble. Each of us carries a whole world inside him...” → **I reason you round.**

Ask (one sentence, in character):

- **The Father** What are you ashamed of that you'll talk around? / When you look at the Step-Daughter, what do you feel?
- **The Mother** What is the one sentence he can never talk you out of?
- **The Step-Daughter** Why is being 'made pretty' worse than being ignored?

20:00 Part V — The Hinge

In it: *The Son, The Father, The Step-Daughter* · *The Son shuts every door.*

- 1 **Read it the Italian way.** The whole part, script in hand, as fast as you can — flat, no emotion, no pauses, cues snapped up the instant they land.
- 2 **Action it — line by line.** For each line I point to, say what you are doing to the other person as *subject – verb – object*: “I ____ you.” One strong verb per thought, pencilled in.

Worked example **The Son:** “Don't look at me. I don't come into this.” → **I shut you out.**

Ask (one sentence, in character):

- **The Son** Why don't you want to be here? / What were you promised as a child that you never got? / What would you do if you could just walk out?
- **The Manager** What do you risk if you listen to them?

20:15 Part VI — The Bargain

In it: *The Father*, *The Manager*, *The Step-Daughter* · He sells the tragedy; the Manager buys.

- 1 **Read it the Italian way.** The whole part, script in hand, as fast as you can — flat, no emotion, no pauses, cues snapped up the instant they land.
- 2 **Action it — line by line.** For each line I point to, say what you are doing to the other person as *subject – verb – object*: “**I ____ you.**” One strong verb per thought, pencilled in.

Worked example **The Father:** “You must be the author. You need not invent us — only give us form.” → **I recruit you.**

Ask (one sentence, in character):

- **The Father** What are you offering him — and what are you hiding? / What can a stage give you that nothing else can? / What happens to you if he says no?
- **The Manager** What finally makes you say yes? / What do you tell yourself to justify it? / What are you already imagining the audience will think?
- **The Step-Daughter** What are you afraid they'll make pretty? / Which part of the story must they keep, no matter what? / What do you want out of being watched?

A bit of practice · 20:35

To finish: pick one or two parts and run them once more — still seated — this time *playing the actions* we found, at a normal pace, cues tight. Not a performance; just a taste of the scene standing on its own feet, so everyone leaves with the act in the body. Then a go-round: one sentence each — “*In Act One, I am trying to ____.*”

Break after The Veil (about 19:10). We are reading to discover, not to perform — nothing is fixed tonight. The staging comes in August; tonight is the words, the cues, and the actions under them.